

MLS Attendance vs Performance

Does winning drive attendance in Major League Soccer? · 2022–2025

Overall correlation

0.086

Winning barely affects attendance

Most loyal fanbase

Philadelphia Union

Attends regardless of results · -0.799

Most performance driven

D.C. United

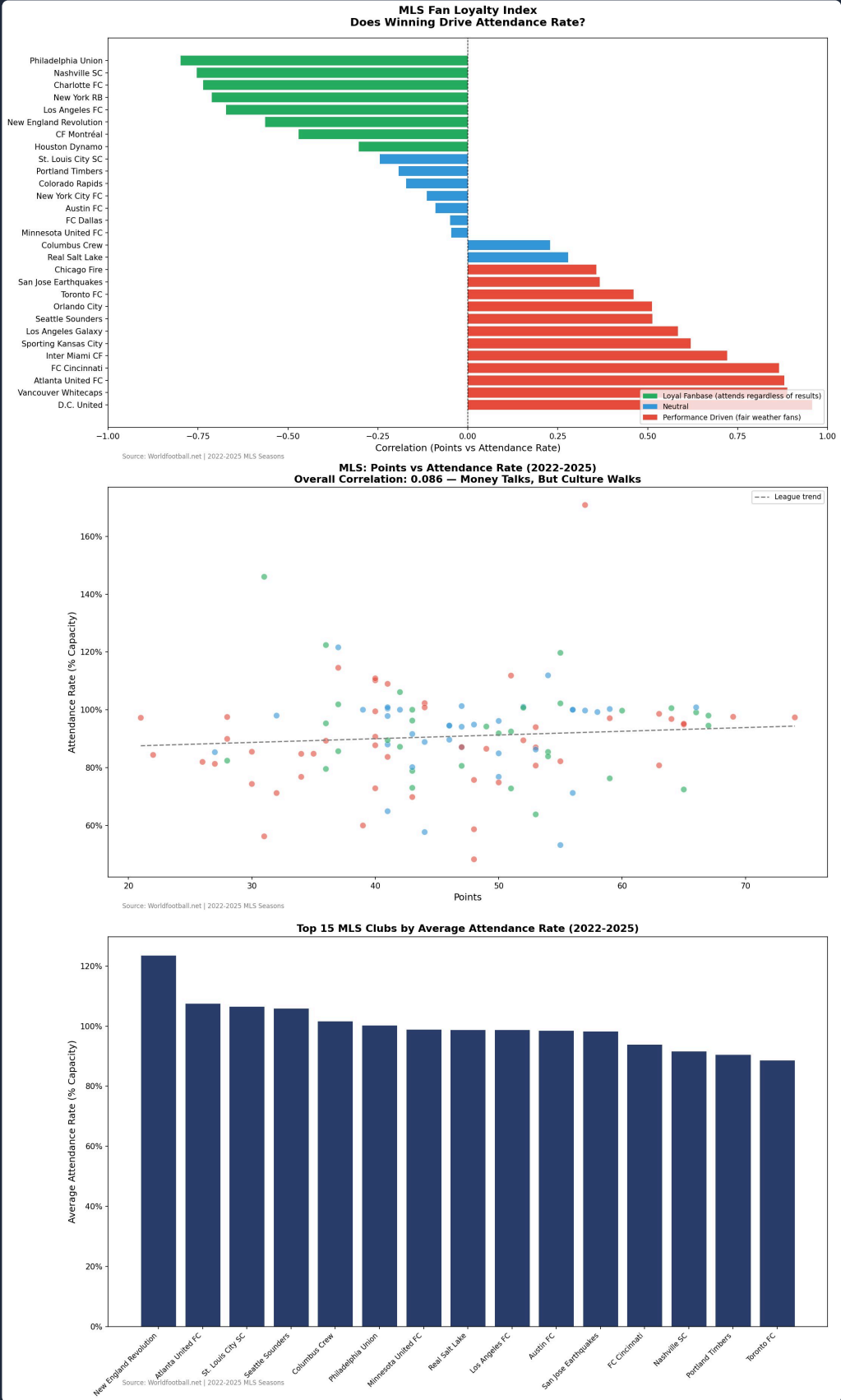
Fair weather fans · +0.957

Key Findings

Analysis of four MLS seasons (2022–2025) reveals virtually no relationship between team performance and attendance. Winning is not the main driver of MLS attendance in the short term, though it can influence attendance for clubs with available capacity. Over time, sustained success can help build larger and more loyal fanbases.

While some clubs show stronger loyalty patterns than others, the data suggests caution in singling out individual teams — more seasons of data would be needed to make those claims confidently. What the overall picture does reveal is that MLS attendance is fundamentally "noisier" than a simple wins-and-losses story.

MLS attendance is influenced by so many other factors — expansion hype, stadium experience, summer weather, designated player signings — that points earned become a secondary concern for the average attendee. Winning helps, but it is rarely the deciding factor in whether fans show up.



★ KEY INSIGHT

MLS attendance is shaped by a wide range of factors — expansion hype, stadium experience, summer scheduling, and marquee designated player signings — that make on-field performance a secondary driver for the average fan. The noise in the data is the story: culture and context matter far more than the standings.

EPL Attendance vs Performance

How do English Premier League fans compare? · 2021–2025

Year-over-year correlation

-0.112

Slight negative relationship

Most loyal fanbase

Burnley FC

Attends regardless of results

Avg capacity filled

95.8%

EPL stadiums nearly always full

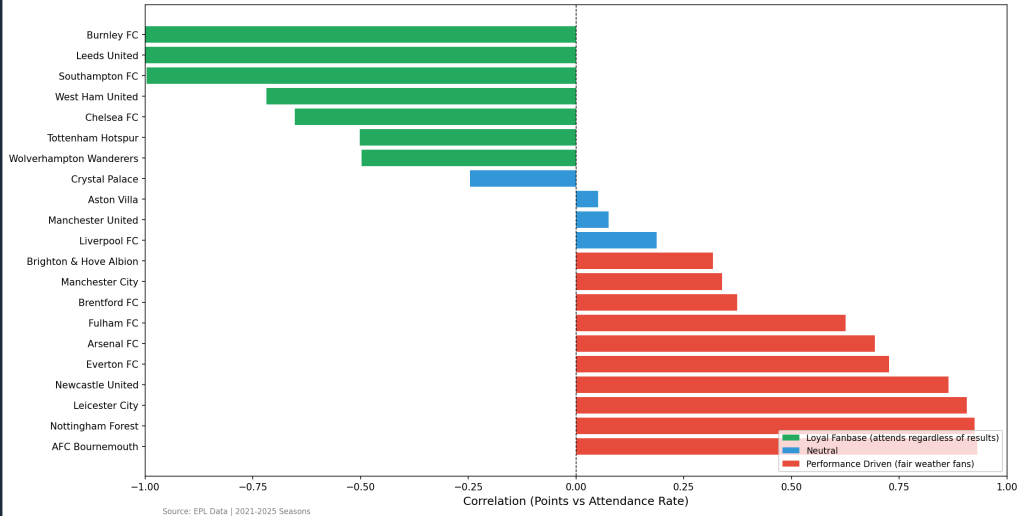
Key Findings

EPL stadiums operate at 95%+ capacity regardless of performance. Year-over-year analysis shows a correlation of -0.112 between performance changes and attendance changes — essentially zero. The slight negative correlation exists because EPL clubs are capacity-constrained, not because fans are disloyal.

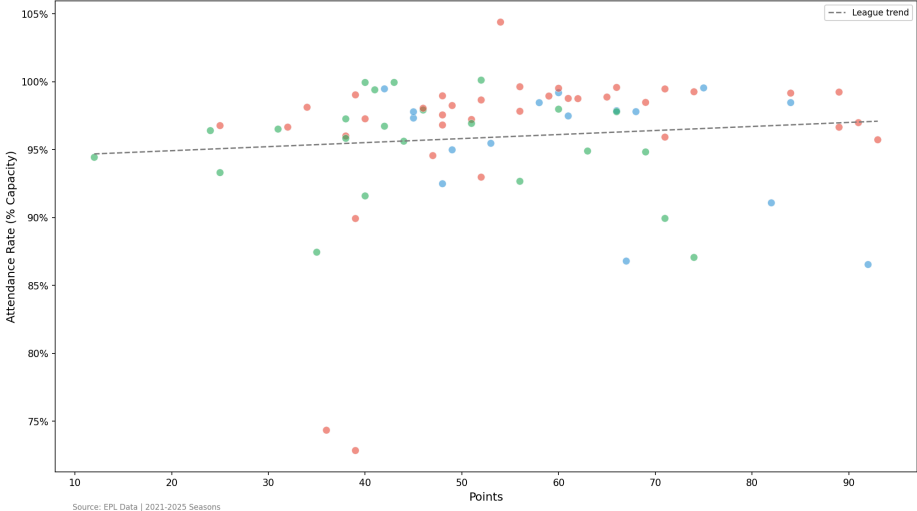
Clubs like Burnley, Leeds, and Southampton maintain near-capacity crowds even during poor seasons because ticket demand far exceeds supply. The few EPL clubs showing "performance-driven" patterns aren't fair-weather fanbases — they simply have excess capacity that allows attendance to fluctuate.

This reveals a fundamental difference from MLS: EPL attendance is supply-constrained (stadiums are full regardless of results), while MLS attendance is demand-constrained (stadiums have empty seats even in good seasons).

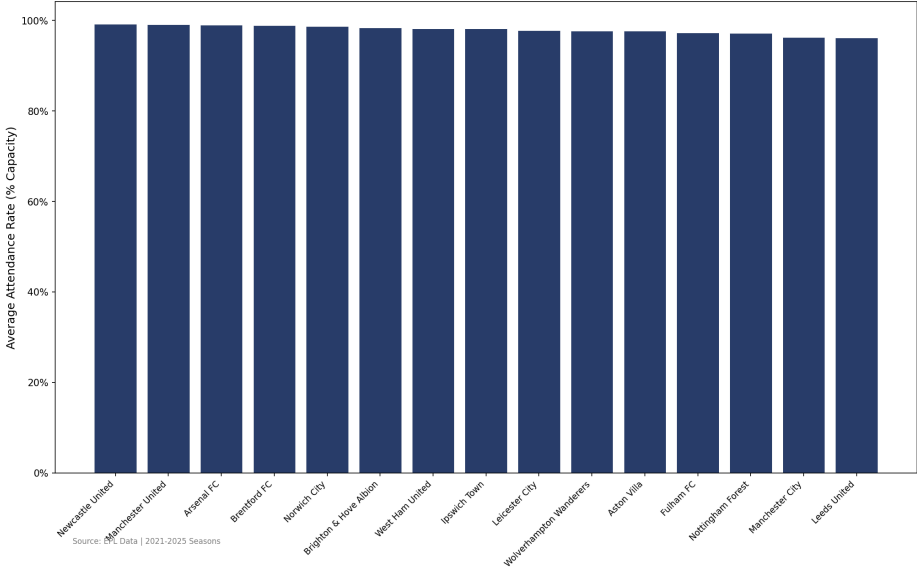
EPL Fan Loyalty Index Does Winning Drive Attendance Rate?



EPL: Points vs Attendance Rate (2021-2025) Overall Correlation: 0.113 — Money Talks, But Culture Walks



Top 15 EPL Clubs by Average Attendance Rate (2021-2025)



★ KEY INSIGHT

EPL fans don't abandon clubs when performance drops. Year-over-year analysis controlling for stadium capacity confirms fans attend at 95%+ regardless of league position. Culture and generational loyalty drive attendance, not short-term results.

MLS vs EPL: A Tale of Two Markets

What American soccer can learn from English football culture

MLS average capacity 87.4% Room to grow attendance	EPL average capacity 95.8% Consistently near sellouts	Year-over-year (MLS) 0.086 Performance change ≠ attendance change	Year-over-year (EPL) -0.112 Slight negative relationship
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Reading the Data

Performance has little overall impact on attendance in either league, with R² values close to zero across both MLS and the EPL. The key difference between the two leagues is structural.

EPL clubs are capacity-constrained — they operate near full attendance regardless of performance because demand consistently exceeds supply. There is simply no room for results to move the needle. MLS clubs, by contrast, have more variability. In some cases, teams with available capacity do see attendance respond to performance — but even then, attendance is more consistently driven by factors like market size, fan engagement, and external demand drivers rather than winning alone.

The conclusion is not that MLS fans are indifferent to results. It is that winning is one input among many, and often not the loudest one.

What MLS Can Learn from the EPL

The data needs more seasons to make strong claims about individual clubs, but the league-wide pattern is clear: MLS attendance volatility is not primarily a performance story. Factors like a new stadium opening, a marquee designated player signing, or even favorable summer scheduling can move attendance as much as a playoff run. These are the real levers club executives and investors should be studying.

The strategic implication: MLS clubs should invest in the experience around the game — stadium quality, community identity, marquee signings — as aggressively as they invest in winning. In a league where the standings explain almost none of the attendance variance, the off-field product is the competitive moat.



FINAL TAKEAWAY

Both MLS and EPL show near-zero correlation between performance and attendance — but for entirely different reasons. EPL stadiums are full because demand exceeds supply. MLS attendance is noisy because so many factors beyond winning drive fans through the gates: expansion energy, designated players, stadium experience, and summer timing. For MLS clubs and investors alike, building the off-field product is not a nice to have — it should go hand in hand with on-field success.